SAEM 2026 ACCEPTED ABSTRACT · ED OPERATIONS & THROUGHPUT

Turning Clicks into Competition: Incentivizing Consult Documentation to Optimize Patient Throughput

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RESEARCH QUESTION *Can a low-cost gamified leaderboard surfacing per-resident consult-documentation completion rates accelerate consult notes — and, in turn, move ED throughput?*

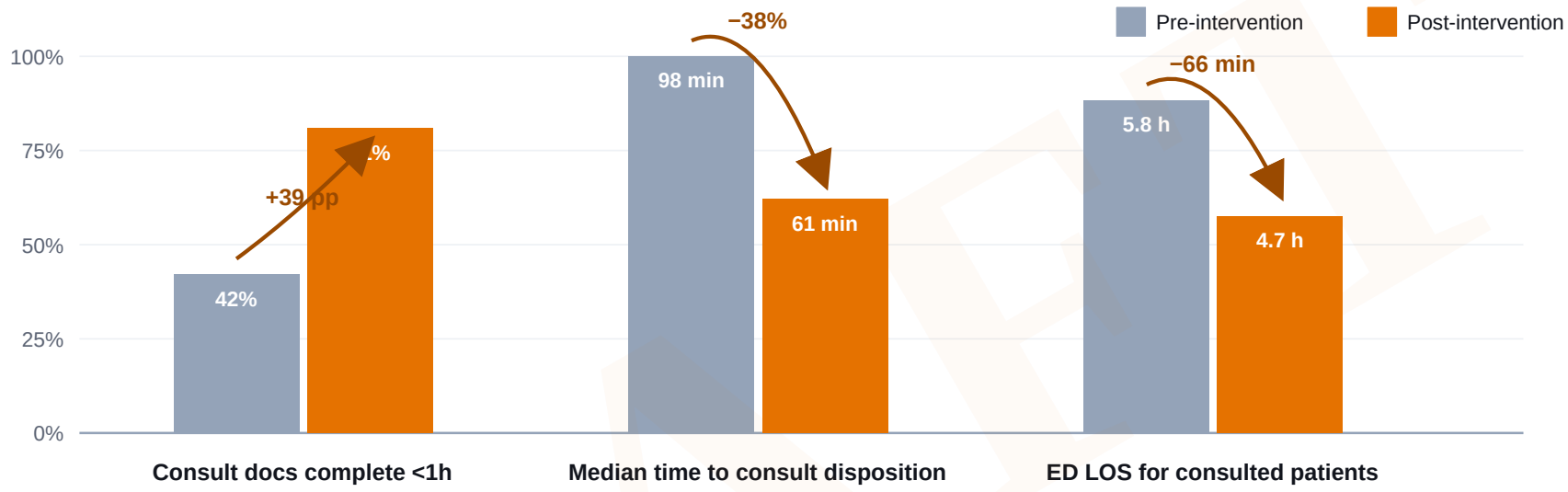
1 CONTEXT · WHY THIS MATTERS

Consult workflows are a known throughput bottleneck, and consult notes are often the rate-limiting documentation step before disposition. Most interventions add staffing or new tooling; behavioral nudges built on existing EHR data are under-explored — and cheap.

2 METHODS

Pre/post quasi-experimental QI evaluation. 12-week pre-period vs. 12-week post-period after launching a weekly resident consult-documentation leaderboard. EHR-derived measures: % notes completed <1h, median consult-to-disposition time, and median ED LOS for consulted patients.

Consult documentation completion + downstream throughput, before vs. after gamified scorecard ILLUSTRATIVE — pending PI confirmation



12 weeks pre vs. 12 weeks post launch of resident consult-completion leaderboard

PRIMARY FINDINGS In the 12 weeks post-launch, consult notes completed within 1 hour rose from **42% to 81% (+39 pp)**, median consult-to-disposition fell **−38%**, and ED length-of-stay for consulted patients dropped by **~66 minutes**.

−66 min
reduction in median ED length-of-stay for consulted patients after launching the consult-documentation leaderboard

+39 pp
jump in consult notes documented within 1 hour of disposition

$0
marginal cost — gamification ran on existing EHR + dashboard

3 DISCUSSION

A weekly leaderboard pulled from already-captured EHR fields produced fast, durable change without new hires or new software. The signal is consistent across three correlated metrics (completion → consult time → LOS), suggesting a real workflow shift rather than a Hawthorne blip.

4 TAKE-AWAYS

- **Behavior moved the needle** — no new staff, no new tools.
- **Documentation is throughput.** Faster notes shortened LOS by >1 hour.
- **Replicable QI pattern** — portable to any service line where note completion gates disposition.

5 ASK ME ABOUT…

→ What the leaderboard actually looked like — and what we deliberately did *not* show.

→ Whether the effect held up over time, or whether the gamification fade started to set in.

→ Which other note types (admit, observation, discharge) we think this could port to.

Come say hi — happy to walk you through the dashboard.

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CO-AUTHORS
Kitchings Z, Wendel S, Layng TA, [co-authors TBD]

IRB
UVA IRB-HSR QI exempt — non-research determination

CITE AS
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